The most likely reason your plan fails is that your advisor retires before you do.

Performance is not the real risk in a long relationship. Continuity is. And the industry has published the numbers on itself.

RETIRING WITHIN TEN YEARS

35.3%

Of financial advisors, holding 40.1 percent of industry assets. Roughly $14.5 trillion changes hands on the advisor's schedule, not the client's.

WITH NO NAMED SUCCESSOR

$4T

More than a quarter of those advisors do not yet know who takes over. That uncertainty sits on about four trillion dollars of client assets.

PROJECTED SHORTFALL BY 2034

90k to 110k

Advisors the industry expects to be short, between 30 and 37 percent of current headcount, while demand rises into it.

CERULLI ASSOCIATES, U.S. ADVISOR EDITION, 3Q 2026 • MCKINSEY & COMPANY, FEBRUARY 2025

The handoff to the next generation is where these relationships actually end.

Twenty-seven percent of people expecting an inheritance plan to keep their benefactor's advisor. Among those who have already inherited, it is twenty percent. Asked why they left, the leading answer after already having their own advisor was that they never had a relationship with the one they were handed. Only a small minority pointed at investment performance at all. The failure is rarely a portfolio failure. It is a relationship built to serve one generation and never introduced to the next.

CERULLI ASSOCIATES, SEPTEMBER 2025 • SURVEY OF INVESTORS WITH $250,000 OR MORE IN FINANCIAL ASSETS

5×

The question underneath this one is usually about software.

Nearly every household weighing an advisor now asks some version of whether a machine will do it instead. Affluent households have already answered: they are willing to pay roughly five times more for human advice than for a comparable digital service, even when the digital service is cheaper. Among investors above $1 million, the share willing to pay a premium of 100 basis points or more grew by half between 2021 and 2023. The scarce resource is not the model. It is a person still holding the whole picture in twenty years, when the decisions that matter are being made by your children.

MCKINSEY & COMPANY, FEBRUARY 2025

I am 29. I intend to be doing this when your children are making these decisions.

Seven years in the industry, nearly six of them at Dimensional Fund Advisors across four groups. CFA Level III candidate. Series 7 and Series 66. Licensed in Illinois and Texas. Driftwood Wealth is the private-wealth practice of Alec Messino, and the work is coordination: making the portfolio, the tax return, and the estate documents agree with each other before a deadline forces the question.

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